

A program of
Stamford Peace Youth Foundation

BEYOND LIMITS NEWSLETTER

SEPTEMBER
2026

READY, SET, SUCCEED: THE 2026–27 SCHOOL YEAR BEGINS

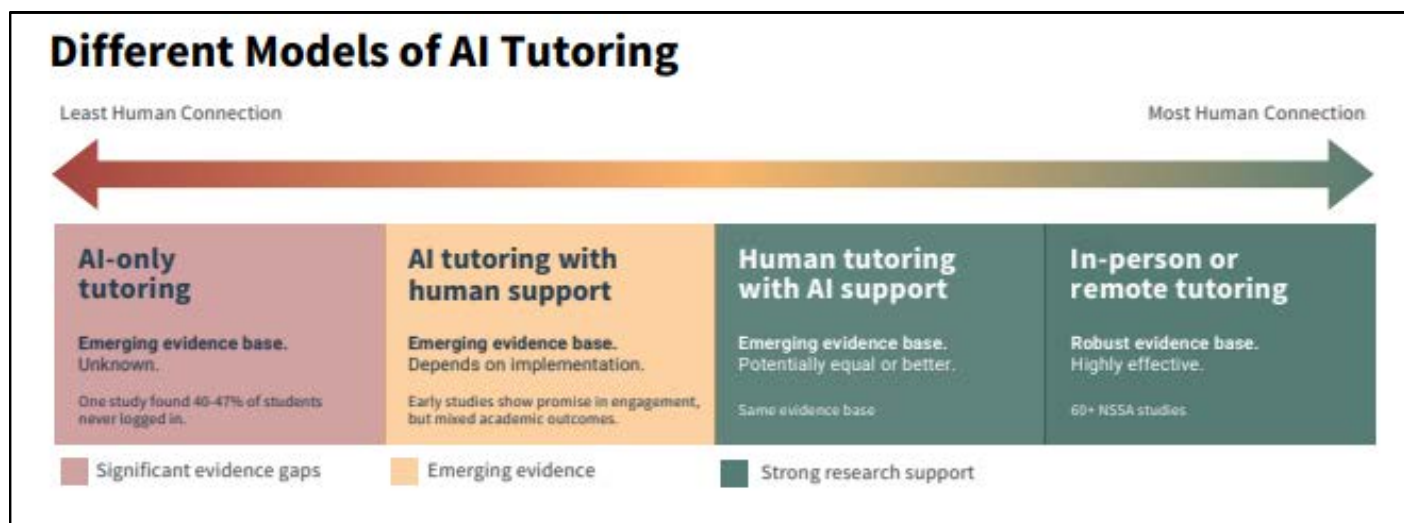
A New Beginning

As summer break comes to a close and backpacks make their way towards the front door, Beyond Limits Academics is gearing up for an exciting new school year! Whether your child is returning to build on last year's progress or starting fresh with new goals, we're here to help every student step into the classroom with confidence. This season is all about setting the foundation for growth — new routines, renewed focus, and the tools to go beyond limits. In this newsletter, we'll share updates on our programs and ways we're supporting students as they kick off a successful year ahead.



The future of tutoring isn't AI replacing humans — it's AI empowering them

Non-profit organizations, like so many "businesses," are well positioned to benefit from the thoughtful adoption of Artificial Intelligence — not just administratively and operationally, but also in how they serve their missions. We're watching the developments in AI tutoring closely, and one model in particular is gaining real traction: human tutoring, AI-supported.



Source: National Student Support Accelerator & AI Hub for Education, Stanford SCALE Initiative, "AI Tutoring Is Not a Monolith" (Aug. 2026)

What We're Reading

We're always reading about education trends and developments — local, regional, state, and national — including, of course, Artificial Intelligence, and a whole lot more. All with a keen focus on ways Beyond Limits can reduce the opportunity gap and effectively build durable (life) skills, starting in middle school. Here are two (2) examples of a plethora of articles, papers, studies, and podcasts we pay close attention to: [Gaining Status: Soft Skills Count for Credit at Maine, Kansas Colleges](#) (The74) and [What Do Students Lose When They Stop Writing?](#) (The New York Times) — [click on titles for link to the article](#).



SUMMER 2026 – 10 YEARS OF MSSSP



Every summer, Beyond Limits' Middle School Summer Scholars Program (MSSSP) welcomes rising sixth graders for a one-week bridge experience designed to ease the transition into middle school. This August, Beyond Limits celebrated the 10th Anniversary of our MSSSP, which combines academic enrichment with social-emotional preparation, giving kids a head start on the school year ahead — and a chance to make friends before the first bell even rings. Over the course of the week, students take part in hands-on STEAM activities, team-building exercises,

and guided conversations about what to expect socially and organizationally in sixth grade, all led by staff and peer mentors who know the transition firsthand.

This year, MSSSP welcomed 37 rising sixth graders, and at the close of the program, we surveyed their parents to find out how the week went from a family's perspective. The results were some of the strongest we've seen in the program's decade-long history, and they reflect what our staff sees in the classroom every day: MSSSP works.



“Turn off your email; turn off your phone; disconnect from the Internet; figure out a way to set limits so you can concentrate when you need to, and disengage when you need to. Technology is a good servant but a bad master.” – Gretchen Rubin, Author and Podcaster

PARENTS GIVE MSSSP A NEAR-PERFECT REPORT CARD

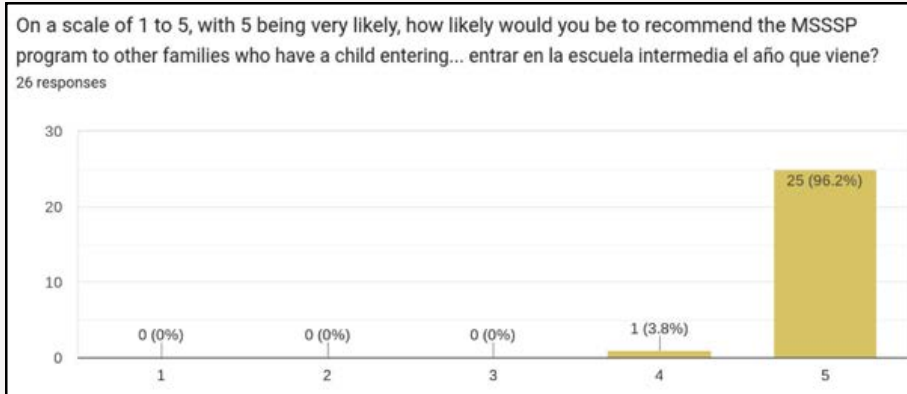
The Numbers

Kids loved it. When asked to rate their child's enjoyment on a scale of 1 to 5, 88% of parents gave the program a perfect 5, and 96% rated it a 4 or higher.

Parents saw real value. Asked how helpful the program was in preparing their child for middle school — even acknowledging it's just one week — 80% of parents

rated it a 5 out of 5, with 96% rating it a 4 or higher. **Word is spreading.** Nearly half of families (48%) said a referral from another family led them to enroll, while another 36% cited the program's reputation. Just as encouraging: 88% of families had no prior connection to MSSSP through a sibling or friend, meaning the program is reaching new families each year.

Families want more. A striking 88% of Parents said they're interested in enrolling their child in our year-round math and science tutoring — a strong signal that MSSSP is successfully opening the door to Beyond Limits' full range of programming. **They're telling their friends.** When asked how likely they'd be to recommend MSSSP to other families, 96% of parents gave the program a perfect 5 out of 5.



In Their Own Words

The written feedback told an even fuller story. Parents described a program that built academic skills and confidence in equal measure:

"My child had a very positive experience in the MSSSP summer program. The program provided a great balance of academics, activities, and opportunities to build confidence and friendships."

"It's such a great program for the kids, especially to get to know other kids who will be starting middle school — it's such a big transition, and to be able to socialize and have a great time learning and experiencing new things."

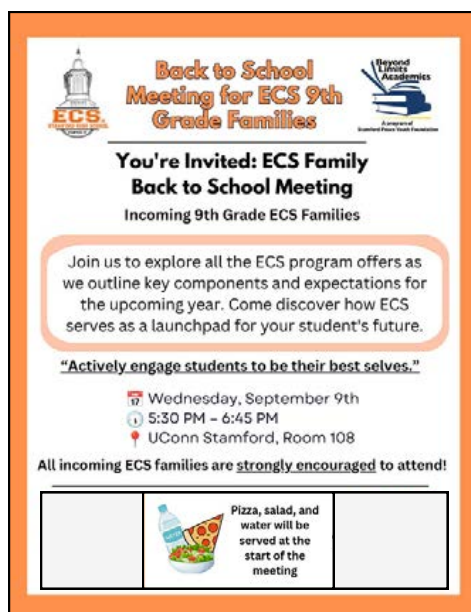


What This Tells Us



This year's survey reinforces three things we've long believed about MSSSP: it delivers real academic and social & emotional value in a short window, it earns trust through word of mouth rather than marketing, and it serves as a natural on-ramp into deeper engagement with Beyond Limits' tutoring program.

As MSSSP celebrates its 10th anniversary, we're proud that a decade in, the program is still meeting — and exceeding — the needs of the families it was built for. Thank you to every parent who took the time to share feedback. Your voices help us keep building a program worthy of your trust.



Early College, Big Futures

Stamford High School's Early College Studies (ECS) program helps students build the skills they need to succeed in high school, college, and the workforce, while preparing them for careers in computer science.

Through a partnership with CT State, Norwalk students can earn both a high school diploma and an associate's degree in computer science in as little as four years, or over five or six years.

As a founding partner of the ECS Program, Beyond Limits is proud to continue working with Stamford High School to support its newest ECS cohort.

Ready to Help?

Beyond Limits exists because ordinary people decided to do something extraordinary — and that's where you come in. Whether you've got an hour a month or a passion you want to turn into action, there's a place for you here. From hands-on volunteering to sharing your skills, spreading the word, or lending your voice to a cause that matters, every contribution moves us closer to eliminating the opportunity gap.

You don't need special training or a big time commitment to make a real difference. You just need to show up.

Get involved today — because together, we go beyond limits. For volunteer opportunities, please email us at info@beyondlimitsacademics.org

Retirement, Reimagined

For many of our region's retirees, the question isn't how to fill the extra hours in a day — it's how to fill them with purpose. After decades of careers, parenting, and packed schedules, the shift to a slower pace can leave a surprising void. Beyond Limits offers one answer: a chance to bring your life experience, patience, and wisdom into a room full of kids hungry for that kind of steady, caring presence. Students benefit from the depth of experience retirees bring, while retirees find renewed purpose, routine, community, and joy. It's not just about filling a schedule; it's about being part of something that matters, one afternoon at a time.



A gift today helps us plan for tomorrow.

To make a secure donation, visit www.peaceyouthct.org/donate or scan the QR code. Your gift helps students access tutoring, mentoring, enrichment, and the support they need to succeed in school and beyond!

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Your time and donations are the heart of our mission.